

Building Your Resilience: Reflecting Through the Pagoda Metaphor

Reflect on your experiences and challenges through the pagoda metaphor, exploring support, balance, and adaptability in your transition to university.



- What are three core values that are most important to you, and how do they guide your decisions?
- How has your sense of identity changed or remained the same since transitioning to university?
- What challenges have made you question your values or identity, and how have you responded to them?



- Who are the key people in your life who provide support, and how do they help you during challenging times?
- How do you maintain healthy boundaries in relationships while adapting to new social environments at university?
- What strategies can you use to build new supportive connections while keeping existing relationships strong?



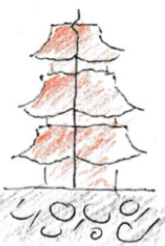
- What are the different layers of support available to you at university (e.g., friends, family, faculty, mental health services), and how do they help you?
- How comfortable do you feel reaching out for support when needed, and what might make it easier for you?
- What proactive steps can you take to strengthen your support network before a crisis occurs?



- How do you currently distribute your time between academic work, social life, self-care, and relaxation?
- What aspects of your routine feel unbalanced, and what small changes could help restore stability?
- If stress levels were rising, what would be the first area in your life that you would adjust to maintain balance?



- Think about a recent challenge you faced—how did you adapt, and what coping strategies helped you?
- What are your go-to strategies for managing stress, and how well do they work for you?
- How can you develop greater emotional flexibility to handle unexpected changes more effectively?



- What routines or habits provide you with a sense of stability in your daily life?
- How does your current routine support (or hinder) your well-being, and what changes would you like to make?
- If your schedule was suddenly disrupted, what steps could you take to regain a sense of stability?

We welcome your comments and suggestions — contact us at embodys@lancaster.ac.uk to share your thoughts or ask any questions!

Personalised Transition and Resilience Kit

Supporting University Students in their Transition to Campus Life

This Kit explores key aspects of student resilience, from maintaining emotional stability to developing strong support networks

—helping you create a foundation for thriving during your university journey.

Why This Matters

The transition to university is a major life change that brings new opportunities but also significant challenges. Moving to campus often means leaving behind familiar support networks, adapting to academic demands, and managing personal responsibilities like meal planning, budgeting, and self-care. Studies show that disruptions in diet, sleep, and social support can negatively impact students' mental health, increasing the risk of stress, anxiety, and depression. By acknowledging these challenges and preparing for them, students can build a resilient foundation for university life.

The Earthquake Metaphor

Adjusting to campus life can feel like navigating an earthquake-prone landscape—unexpected disruptions to routine, relationships, and well-being can shake a student's foundation. However, just as earthquake-resistant structures are built with resilience in mind, students can develop strategies to cope with and adapt to these new challenges.

Inspired by the Japanese pagoda (see page 3), a structure designed to withstand seismic forces, resilience in university life can be understood as a layered system. A strong sense of self-awareness, values, and purpose provides emotional stability during difficult transitions. A diverse network of friends, mentors, student support services, and mental health resources acts as protective layers, distributing stress and preventing burnout. Developing coping strategies such as mindfulness, time management, and seeking support allows students to handle stress without feeling overwhelmed. Establishing consistent sleep patterns, balanced nutrition, and regular physical activity provides a solid foundation for mental well-being.

Crafting Resilience

Resilience is not built overnight—it requires continuous adaptation and learning. The transition to university is a period of growth, and students must learn to navigate their new reality by adopting practical, sustainable habits. The Japanese concept of Kaizen, meaning continuous improvement, teaches that small, steady refinements in daily routines, social habits, and academic strategies lead to long-term resilience. Rather than expecting perfection, the philosophy of Wabi-sabi, which embraces imperfection, reminds students to see setbacks as natural and valuable parts of learning. Resilience is about recognizing that growth happens gradually and that moments of struggle do not define the journey but shape it.

The Master-Apprentice Relationship

Learning from mentors, peers, and university staff is crucial in developing resilience. Just as in traditional craftsmanship, where an apprentice learns not only technical skills but also patience and adaptability from a master, students benefit from seeking guidance from experienced individuals. Connecting with upper-year students or college advisors can provide practical advice and emotional support. Professors and academic advisors can help students navigate academic challenges and career goals. Joining student groups, volunteering, or participating in extracurricular activities fosters a sense of belonging and shared learning, reinforcing the idea that resilience is best developed through community and mentorship.

Mentorship creates a ripple effect, empowering both mentor and mentee while enriching the entire community. It's this collaborative spirit that drives our co-design approach, ensuring the Kit reflects real-world challenges and solutions.

Breaking Down Complexity

The challenges of university life—balancing academics, personal growth, and social responsibilities—can feel overwhelming. However, breaking these challenges into manageable steps can make adaptation easier. In craftsmanship, intricate designs are completed step by step, with patience and attention to detail. Similarly, approaching university life through gradual, deliberate changes can help students build resilience without feeling overburdened.

Sleep hygiene and circadian rhythm regulation play a critical role in maintaining emotional stability. A consistent sleep schedule, reduced screen exposure at night, and a relaxing bedtime routine can help prevent fatigue and mood fluctuations. Nutrition is another key factor. Learning basic cooking skills, prioritizing whole foods, and minimizing reliance on processed meals can support overall well-being. Social connection is equally important. Engaging in campus activities, maintaining contact with family, and seeking peer support can provide stability during times of transition. Finally, managing academic and financial pressures requires effective time management, realistic goal-setting, and budgeting strategies to reduce unnecessary stress.

Tailoring Solutions: Respect for Individuality

Every student experiences the transition to university differently. The Kit is designed to be flexible, allowing students to customize their strategies based on their personal strengths, challenges, and values. Just as a master craftsman tailors their approach to the unique qualities of different materials, students can adapt their strategies to fit their own needs. Creating an individualized study, social, and self-care plan helps students take ownership of their well-being. Some students may require additional tailored resources and support, such as those with mental health problems, learning differences, or financial constraints. Emerging technologies, such as mental health apps and AI-driven study tools, can also provide students with personalized coping mechanisms that align with their unique needs.

Preparedness for Acute Situations

During high-stress periods such as exam seasons, social conflicts, or personal crises, students need pre-prepared coping strategies to prevent overwhelm. The principle of *Mottainai*, which emphasizes efficiency and resourcefulness, teaches the value of having simple, effective strategies that can be accessed quickly. Techniques such as box breathing, grounding exercises, and structured relaxation can help regulate emotional responses in moments of distress. Keeping a resilience journal, having emergency mental health contacts readily available, and proactively utilizing campus mental health resources can provide additional layers of security. The ability to anticipate stressors and plan for them in advance allows students to maintain stability even in unpredictable situations.

Finding Strength in Repair

University life is full of unexpected challenges, but growth and transformation come from overcoming obstacles. Inspired by *Kintsugi*, the Japanese art of repairing broken pottery with gold, we recognize that struggles and setbacks can lead to greater resilience and strength. Rather than hiding difficulties, students can embrace them as part of their unique journey, understanding that imperfections and challenges contribute to personal growth. Just as a broken object can be repaired in a way that highlights its history, students can learn from adversity and emerge stronger, more self-aware, and more adaptable.

Central Pillar (Shinbashira) = Core Values and Self-Identity

Ancient Buildings: The central pillar in pagodas acts as a stabilising "spine," helping the structure distribute seismic forces and maintain balance.

Human Experience: A strong sense of self-identity and core values acts as a stabilizing force for students transitioning to university. Moving away from home, adjusting to new academic and social environments, and managing newfound independence can feel like an emotional earthquake. However, a clear understanding of personal values and self-identity helps maintain stability amid these changes. Whether it's a commitment to academic integrity, personal growth, or cultural identity, these core values can serve as an internal anchor that provides direction and resilience throughout the transition.

Joint Construction without Nails = Healthy Relationships

Ancient Buildings: The joints in ancient wooden buildings are designed to be flexible, allowing the building to move and sway without snapping or breaking. This flexibility is crucial for absorbing seismic shocks.

Human Experience: Healthy, adaptable relationships play a key role in a student's transition to university life. Friendships, relationships with professors, and connections with mentors can provide emotional support and encouragement. Just as flexible joints allow a pagoda to withstand earthquakes, relationships that accommodate change and personal growth can help students navigate the uncertainties of university life. The ability to communicate openly, set boundaries, and develop new social connections can contribute to emotional stability and personal well-being.

Multi-Tiered Roofs = Social Support, Layered Resources and Crisis Prevention

Ancient Buildings: The multi-tiered roofs in pagodas help distribute the forces of an earthquake, acting like shock absorbers that slow down and spread out the shaking.

Human Experience: A student's support system should function like the layered roofs of a pagoda, providing multiple levels of security and assistance. This includes family, friends, academic advisors, mental health resources, and student organizations. When challenges arise—whether academic stress, homesickness, or mental health struggles—these different layers of support can work together to distribute the emotional load, preventing one area from becoming overwhelmed. Universities that offer counseling services, peer mentoring programs, and student-led support groups can create a stronger foundation for student well-being.

Symmetrical and Simple Design = Balanced Lifestyle

Ancient Buildings: The symmetrical and simple designs of ancient buildings help distribute stress evenly during an earthquake, reducing the concentration of forces on any one part of the structure.

Human Experience: Maintaining a balanced lifestyle is essential for students adapting to university life. Academic demands, social activities, part-time work, and self-care should be distributed in a way that prevents burnout. A structured but flexible routine that includes time for studying, exercise, socializing, and relaxation can help create stability. Overcommitting to one aspect, such as academics or socializing, can lead to stress and exhaustion. A well-balanced routine ensures sustainable success and well-being throughout university life.

Flexible Wooden Structure = Emotional Adaptability and Coping Skills

Ancient Buildings: The flexible wooden structure of Japanese buildings allows them to bend and absorb energy without breaking under stress.

Human Experience: Emotional adaptability and well-developed coping skills can allow students to manage the highs and lows of university life. Being able to adjust to setbacks—whether academic challenges, social difficulties, or unexpected stressors—can prevent emotional breakdowns. Mindfulness practices, problem-solving skills, seeking guidance from mentors, and engaging in stress-management activities (such as exercise or creative outlets) enable students to "bend" with life's challenges without feeling overwhelmed.

Base Isolation (Floating Foundations) = Grounded Daily Routine and Stability

Ancient Buildings: In some ancient structures, the foundation stones allow the building to "float" above the ground, moving slightly with the earthquake rather than fighting against it. This helps absorb the shock and prevent the structure from crumbling.

Human Experience: A stable daily routine can serve as a "floating foundation" for students transitioning to university. Regular sleep patterns, consistent study schedules, meal planning, and time for relaxation can create predictability in an otherwise unpredictable environment. Routine can act as a grounding force, helping students manage stress, maintain productivity, and support their overall mental and physical health. Universities that promote healthy habits and provide spaces for routine-driven activities, such as libraries, wellness programs, and communal dining halls, further reinforce this stability.